

CAPES MONTHLY BRIEF

AUGUST 2026

ISSUE # 15

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ADVANCING INDEPENDENT
DISCOURSE ON ASIA-PACIFIC
& EURASIA



PRE-DEPARTURE ORIENTATION SEMINAR

CAPES in collaboration with the Embassy of Russia in Pakistan, organised a Pre-Departure Orientation Seminar for Pakistani scholars preparing to pursue academic programmes in Russia. The seminar provided participants with practical guidance on travel, documentation, and settling-in procedures, equipping them with the information needed for a smooth transition ahead of their departure.



CAPES SIGNS MOU WITH UNIVERSITY OF LAHORE (UOL)

CAPES has signed an MoU with UoL to facilitate academic and research initiatives and exchanges. A delegation comprising President CAPES Dr. Khuram Iqbal, SVP CAPES Dr. Faisal Javaid, and Senior Research Analyst Muneeb Salman, met with Rector UoL Prof. Dr. Muhammad Ashraf, HoD SISS UoL Dr. Kishwar Munir, and faculty members.

INDONESIA'S APPROACH TO COUNTERING VIOLENT EXTREMISM

CAPES, as part of its Distinguished Lecture Series, organized an online webinar with Dr. Noor Huda Ismail, Visiting Fellow at RSIS Singapore and Founder of the Institute for International Peace Building, Indonesia. During his address, Dr. Ismail stressed that radicalization is relational before it is ideological, with extremist groups exploiting people's need for belonging and recognition rather than ideology alone.



CAPES INTERNSHIP PROGRAM (ONSITE & REMOTE)



Visit to Russian Embassy

CAPES organized a visit to the Russian Embassy in Pakistan, CAPES team and interns engaged in a candid discussion with H.E. Albert P. Khorev, Ambassador of Russia to Pakistan. The conversation covered a range of important topics, including the history and future of Pakistan–Russia relations, educational opportunities for Pakistani students in Russia, and regional developments in the Middle East and South Asia

CAPES EXPERT TALK WITH DR. SAIRA AQUIL

CAPES organized a guest lecture on "From Indo-Pacific Back to Asia-Pacific" by Dr. Saira Aquil, Vice President, CAPES. Dr. Aquil noted that the renaming of the US Indo-Pacific Command back to the US Pacific Command signals a real shift in US strategic priorities, with India no longer viewed as a central actor.

MEETING WITH SERGEY CHEKALIN

CAPES hosted an informal interaction with Mr. Sergey Chekalin, Chief of Protocol at the Embassy of the Russian Federation in Pakistan. The discussion focused on the importance of Regional Studies and the role of language in developing a deeper understanding of different regions and cultures.



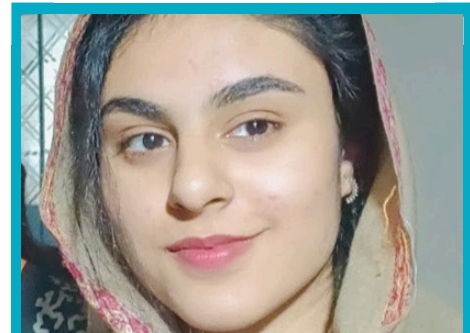
How Alexander Pushkin and Allama Iqbal Complement Each Other

CAPES INTERN
MYRA SAQIB
WRITES FOR GEOPOLITIKA. RU



Understanding the CKU Railway: Kyrgyzstan Beyond the Debt Trap Narrative

CAPES INTERN
AMALIYA KHAIRUN NISA
WRITES FOR MODERN DIPLOMACY



Kazakhstan's Mining Ambitions and the Challenge of Water Security

CAPES INTERN
MAHNOOR KHAN
WRITES FOR STRATHEIA

Beyond the Freight Train: Pakistan's Eurasian Opportunity

**CAPES SENIOR VICE PRESIDENT
DR. FAISAL JAVAID
WRITES FOR
DAILY TIMES**

<https://dailytimespk.com/beyond-the-freight-train-pakistans-eurasian-opportunity/>



"The proposed Pakistan-Russia freight train is more than a railway project. It is a test of whether Pakistan can convert its geography into a strategic and economic advantage as Eurasian trade is reshaped by geopolitical uncertainty. The two sides are working on the route, cargo types, tariffs and delivery times, with the test date to be coordinated with Pakistan and transit countries. Russian Ambassador Albert P. Khorev has similarly stated that freight services connecting Moscow with Karachi and Faisalabad in both directions are being prepared."

Mecca Pact: Warning Only for Those Who Plan to Strike First

**CAPES GENERAL SECRETARY
DR. UMAIR PERVEZ
WRITES FOR
DAILY SABAH**

<https://www.dailysabah.com/opinion/oped/mecca-pact-warning-only-for-those-who-plan-to-strike-first>



"On Aug. 7, in Islam's holiest city, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan signed the Mecca Joint Defense Agreement, declaring that an armed attack on one is an attack on all. Within 72 hours, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu called Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging deeper alignment with Greece, the Greek Cypriot administration, India and the United Arab Emirates (UAE). India's former foreign secretary called the pact a "very negative development for Indian interests." The speed of that reaction is more revealing than the document itself."



Daria Dugina: Remembering a Young Voice of Eurasian Thought

**DIRECTOR, EURASIA CHAPTER
DR. GUL-I-AYESHA BHATTI
WRITES FOR
DAILY TIMES**

<https://dailytimespk.com/daria-dugina-remembering-a-young-voice-of-eurasian-thought/>

"Four years after the car bombing that killed Daria Dugina near Moscow on 20 August 2022, her memory continues to carry a significance that extends beyond the circumstances of her tragic death. She was only 29 when her life was cut short, yet in her brief intellectual and public career she had already emerged as a distinctive young voice within contemporary Eurasian thought. To those who followed her work, she was not simply the daughter of Alexander Dugin, but a journalist, political commentator and thinker"

From Corridors to Clusters: CPEC 2.0 and the Next Phase of Industrial and Technological Cooperation

**CAPES RESEARCH FELLOW
DR. SUNDAS KHIZAR
WRITES FOR
PIVOT MAGAZINE**

https://issi.org.pk/wp-content/uploads/2026/08/PIVOT_Magazine_Aug_2026.pdf



"Indonesia has positioned itself as a successful case study for countries to respond to and adapt to the critical mineral surge, rightfully so. Indonesia is the world's largest nickel producer, accounting for up to 70% of the total global output. Indonesia has been able to do this through structural transformation, moving beyond the extractive model and adding value through downstream processing. Thus, Indonesia is a textbook example of resource-based industrialization"

What Indonesia's Nickel Export Ban Built Over Time?

**CAPES RESEARCHER
HADIA ALLAUDIN
WRITES FOR
STRATHEIA**

<https://stratheia.com/what-indonesias-nickel-export-ban-built-over-time/>



"Indonesia has positioned itself as a successful case study for countries to respond to and adapt to the critical mineral surge, rightfully so. Indonesia is the world's largest nickel producer, accounting for up to 70% of the total global output. Indonesia has been able to do this through structural transformation, moving beyond the extractive model and adding value through downstream processing. Thus, Indonesia is a textbook example of resource-based industrialization"

Abolish the Income Tax

**CAPES NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
MUHAMMAD UMAR,
WRITES FOR THE NEWS**

<https://www.thenews.pk/print/1432680-abolish-the-income-tax>



"It is time to abolish the personal income tax. We have reformed it, and widened the net so often in the past 20 years that the exercise has become a ritual, and the result is always a massive failure. Income tax should be abolished below a threshold high enough that ninety-nine per cent of Pakistanis never file a return again, keep one narrow band above it for the small number whose wealth is beyond argument and tax everything else where money is spent."



PAK-PACIFIC BRIEF

- Pakistan and New Zealand held high-level Bilateral Political Consultations and Joint Trade Committee Meetings in Wellington.
- Pakistani and Philippine parliamentary leaders pledged to enhance bilateral cooperation during meetings on the sidelines of the UNITE Global Summit 2026 in Manila.
- Indonesia announced plans to ease visa procedures for Pakistani citizens to promote business and people-to-people exchanges.
- Chairman Senate Yousaf Raza Gilani met with Abdul Raheem Abdulla, Speaker of Cambodia's parliament and discussed cooperation in different fields.
- Japanese carmaker Suzuki exported a "mini car" from its overseas production base in Pakistan to Brunei.
- DPM & FM Ishaq Dar met Malaysian Home Minister Saifuddin Nasution Ismail, with both sides reaffirming close ties and discussing cooperation in trade, mutual legal assistance, and people-to-people exchanges.
- China and Pakistan signed a technical and investment cooperation agreement on sports equipment.
- Pakistan's Ambassador to Vietnam, Kodayar Marri, spearheaded a series of high-level business meetings to promote bilateral B2B trade linkages.
- Pakistan has presented a USD 4.85 billion climate project pipeline to Chinese investors. The pipeline includes 69 projects across eight sectors.
- The Embassy of Pakistan in Tokyo participated in the Pakistan-Japan Friendship Festival.



PAK-EURASIA BRIEF

- Pakistan has assumed chairmanship of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO).
- PM Shehbaz Sharif undertook a three-day official visit to Kyrgyzstan to attend the SCO Council of Heads of State meeting.
- President Zardari congratulated Kazakh President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev and the Kazakh people on the successful completion of the Kurultai elections.
- Chief Election Commissioner Sikandar Raja held bilateral talks with his Russian counterpart on arrangements for Pakistan to observe Russia's September elections.
- Pakistan and Kazakhstan have reaffirmed their commitment to achieving USD 1 billion in bilateral trade within two years.
- Kyrgyzstan and Pakistan are working on an agreement to develop transit trade.
- Pakistan and Belarus agreed on measures to boost bilateral trade at a two-day Joint Ministerial Commission meeting.
- Russia reopened its market to potato imports from Punjab.
- Russia and Pakistan are working to launch their first freight rail service linking Moscow with Faisalabad and Karachi.
- Kyrgyzstan's Chargé d'Affaires Aibek Tilebaliev met FPCCI President Atif Ikram Sheikh to discuss bilateral trade, investment promotion, and B2B linkages.
- Pakistan will sign an FTA with the Eurasian Economic Union, according to Pakistan's Ambassador to Russia, Faisal Niaz Tirmiz.
- Ishaq Dar led Pakistan's delegation to the SCO Council of Foreign Ministers meeting in Cholpon-Ata, Kyrgyzstan.